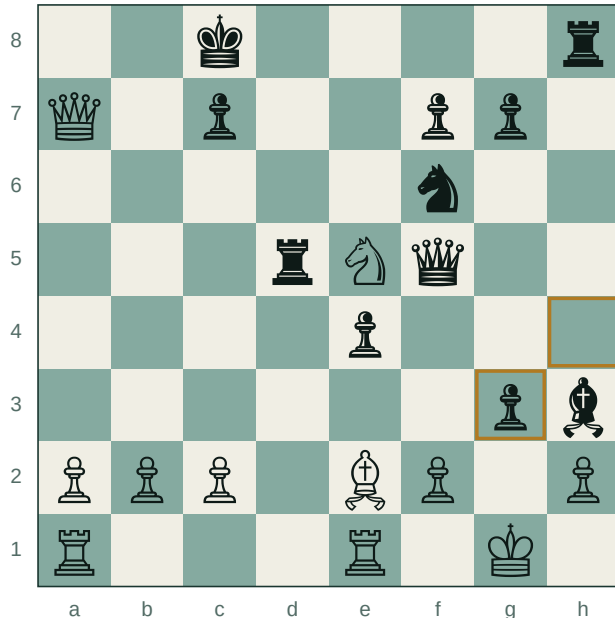


Mate in one: White, move 23

Mate in one

White to move



Previous move: 22...hxc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23. Qa8#

23.Qa8# Mate: queen on a8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on c8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on a8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A checking piece next to the king must be protected unless the king cannot capture it for another legal reason.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Checkmate is a complete restriction of the enemy king. Find a legal check, then prove there is no king escape, capture of the checker, or interposition.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect the king's flight squares before choosing a check. A protected queen or a distant rook may cover the last escape in different ways.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8. Check for tactical protection.